

PROPOSAL · THE ECHELON V0

Intentionally simple and elegant.

The public website and the private Member Portal for The Echelon, built together and launched in six weeks.

PREPARED FOR

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IntenseGBD · The Echelon

PREPARED BY

Upperhand

Chicago

DATE

September 2026



Joe,

Thanks for sending the V0 document, and for the time with John. It gave us a clear brief to work from.

What follows is how we would build V0: the public website and the private Member Portal, launched together. It is built from three things: your document, The Echelon's Executive Overview, and what we have learned building products and companies of our own.

We kept the scope as you wrote it. Members sign in, browse Company Partners, read a profile and press Connect. It stays intentionally simple, and it is built so the things you have set aside for later can arrive on the same foundation.

Your questions are answered below. We'd like to walk you through it on a call.

John Williamson & Greg McDonald

Co-Founders, Upperhand

YOUR QUESTIONS, ANSWERED

The cost to build →	\$7,500 , fixed, from 60 hours at \$125.
Recurring costs →	About \$45 a month for hosting, database and email, plus your Constant Contact plan and the W-9 service's per-form fee.
Timeline and milestones →	Six weeks from kickoff, with each milestone you named.
Mobile first →	Yes. Designed on a phone first and fully responsive.
A Progressive Web App →	Yes, in V0. Members add the portal to their home screen.
A native app later →	Its own project, on the same foundation. Preliminary: \$12,500 to \$20,000.
W-9s →	Handled by a specialist service we connect to the portal. Connecting it is in the fee; its per-form charge is not.
Security and ownership →	Encrypted, with two-factor sign-in for administrators and daily backups. IntenseGBD owns the custom code, data, design files and accounts.

What we're building

01

For Members

Most will use it on a phone. They sign in, browse Company Partners by ecosystem and category, read a profile with its Echelon Member Advantage, and press Connect. The portal sits on their home screen.

02

For prospective Members

They arrive from an Ambassador or a referral. The public site explains The Echelon, its Standards and its two ecosystems, and takes a request for Founding Membership in a short form, with the source and Ambassador captured on the way in.

03

For your team

Approve Members, build Partner profiles, see every connection and keep Constant Contact current, in one admin.

How we build every site

- **Mobile first**

Designed for a phone, then scaled up to the desktop.

- **Fast**

Pages load in under 2 seconds on mobile.

- **Secure**

Encrypted, with a role for each kind of user, two-factor sign-in for administrators and daily backups.

- **Accessible**

Built to WCAG 2.2 AA.

- **Easy to run**

An admin your team uses without a developer.

- **Yours**

IntenseGBD owns the custom code, the design files, the content, the data and every account, with a permanent license to the shared components underneath, and can move all of it to another host or developer.

Scope of work

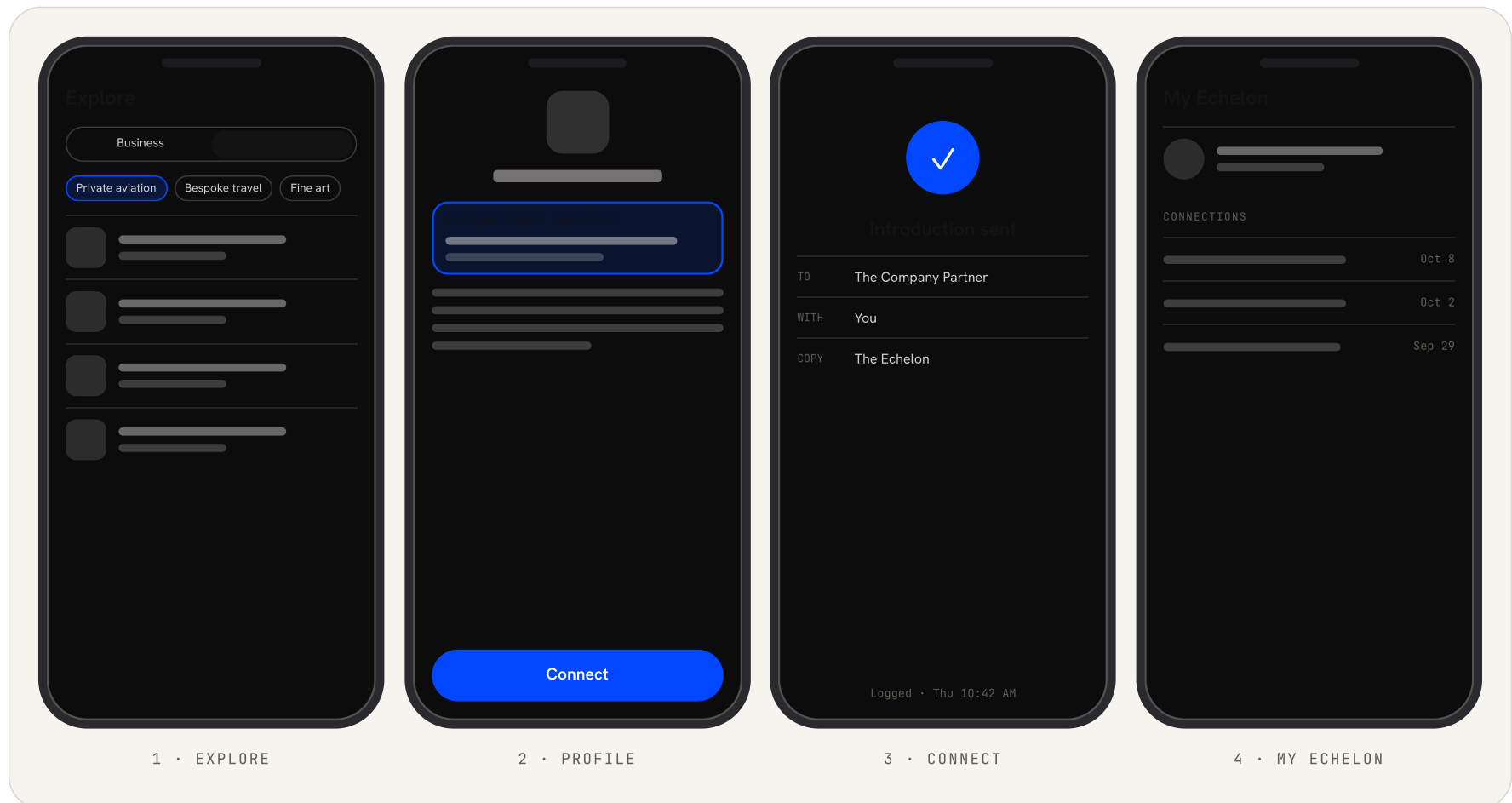
Discovery & planning	One working session on the Member journey, from the request form to the first Connect. We shape the Company Partner profile template around your profile and questionnaire, and settle the roles, the Connect email and the sitemap.
Design	One direction, carried from your logo and brand standards into every page and portal screen, designed on a phone first. We refine it with you within the design weeks, working from one consolidated set of comments at a time.
Public website	Your navigation as written: Home, The Echelon, Explore, Our Standards, Membership and Sign In. Explore shows the ecosystems and categories; Partner profiles stay behind sign-in. Our Standards carries the Company Partner Disclaimer, and so does the footer, with About, Contact, Privacy, Terms and the copyright notice. Membership carries the Request Founding Membership form.
Member Portal	Password sign-in, the Member home, Explore by ecosystem and category, and Company Partner profiles with the Echelon Member Advantage set apart at the top. Connect records the Member, the Partner, the date and the time, then sends your introduction email with IntenseGBD copied. My Echelon shows each Member's account details and connections, videos embed from YouTube, and the portal installs to the home screen as a Progressive Web App.
Administration	Add, edit and remove Members, Company Partners, profiles, categories, Member Advantages and page content. Approve membership requests and send enrollment, where the Member sets a password and accepts your Terms. The connection report exports to CSV, and every Member record keeps its source and Ambassador. Ambassadors are records of their own, so a later dashboard is a new screen rather than a rework.
Integrations & security	Approved Members flow into Constant Contact, email goes out from your domain, and administrators sign in with two-factor authentication. Backups and rate limits are set up before launch.
W-9s	Members open their W-9 from My Echelon, and Ambassadors use a secure link from the same service. In discovery we choose a specialist tax-form service that meets your list: encryption, access limited to your named administrators with two-factor sign-in, a log of every view, and deletion on your schedule. The service holds the forms; admin shows each one's status only. Connecting it is in the fee; the service's per-form charge is not.
Content population	We load the first Company Partner profile with your team as the pattern. Your team loads the rest, and the page copy is yours.
Testing & launch	Testing on iPhone, Android and desktop, user acceptance testing with your team, launch at theechelonsignature.com, admin training with a short written guide, and two weeks of monitoring.

Out of V0, as you set it: transaction or revenue tracking, a separate Ambassador portal or login, Company Partners maintaining their own profiles, sophisticated marketing automation, extensive Member social profiles or community functionality, and proprietary video.

Your brand, carried in

The site starts from The Echelon's own identity: the crest, the navy and gold, and the voice of the Executive Overview. The design round turns that into a system for the web.

For illustration only. These four screens show the path you described, not a design.



Six weeks from kickoff

Each milestone in your document is here: design approval, development, testing, content population, user acceptance testing and launch. Kickoff is within five business days of signing and the first payment. The dates assume comments come back within two business days; if content or legal text arrives late, launch moves by the same number of days, and the fee doesn't change.



01 Discovery & planning

Week 1

A working session on the Member journey and the decisions that shape the build.

WE NEED FROM YOU

two hours, your brand standards and the Company Partner questionnaire

02 Design

Weeks 1 to 3

Every page and portal screen, phone first, refined with you until you approve it.

WE NEED FROM YOU

one decision-maker, and comments in one set

03 Development

Weeks 2 to 5

The website, the portal, admin, Constant Contact, W-9s and security. A staging link updates every week.

WE NEED FROM YOU

the Constant Contact account, access to your domain's DNS, and the final text of your legal pages

04 Content population

Weeks 4 to 5

Your team loads the Company Partners, with the first one done together.

WE NEED FROM YOU

the launch Partners' profile information and logos

05 Testing & user acceptance

Weeks 5 to 6

We test on iPhone, Android and desktop, then your team uses it for real and tells us what they find.

WE NEED FROM YOU

your sign-off that it is ready

06 Launch

Week 6

The site replaces "Launching Soon" at theechelonsignature.com and the portal opens to approved Members.

WE NEED FROM YOU

your first invitations, ready to send through Constant Contact

07 Monitoring

Weeks 6 to 8

Two weeks of monitoring, and fixes for anything that does not work as scoped.

WE NEED FROM YOU

anything your team or Members notice

Fee and payment terms

V0 is priced at **60** hours at our project rate of \$125 an hour, as one fixed fee: if the work runs past that, it is ours to absorb. It covers everything from kickoff to two weeks after launch, including connecting the W-9 service.

Payment terms

Three equal payments: one at signing, one when you approve the design at the end of week 3, and one at launch.

What would change it

Work not listed here, such as a second design direction, Upperhand loading all the Partner profiles, or any of the bigger builds under After launch. We would price it in hours at the same rate before starting.

This proposal holds through October 31, 2026.

1/3 At signing **\$2,500**
Payment 1 • Before kickoff

1/3 Design approved **\$2,500**
Payment 2 • Week 3

1/3 Launch **\$2,500**
Payment 3 • Week 6

LINE	ITEM	HOURS × RATE
01	Discovery & planning 4 hrs × \$125 - One working session on the Member journey, from the request form to the first Connect - The Company Partner profile template, shaped around your profile and questionnaire - Roles, the Connect email and the sitemap, signed off before design starts	\$500
02	Design 10 hrs × \$125 - One direction, carried from your logo and brand standards into every page and screen - Designed on a phone first, then the desktop - Refined with you within the design weeks, from one consolidated set of comments at a time	\$1,250
03	Public website 7 hrs × \$125 - Home, The Echelon, Explore, Our Standards, Membership and Sign In, plus the footer pages - The Request Founding Membership form, with the source and Ambassador captured	\$875
04	Member Portal 14 hrs × \$125 - Password sign-in, the Member home, Explore and Company Partner profiles - Connect: logged at the button, then your introduction email, with IntenseGBD copied - My Echelon with account details and connections, YouTube embeds, and a Progressive Web App for the home screen	\$1,750
05	Administration 9 hrs × \$125 - Members, Company Partners, profiles, categories, Member Advantages and page content - The membership queue and enrollment, and the connection report with a CSV export - Source and Ambassador on every Member record	\$1,125
06	Integrations & security 4 hrs × \$125 - Constant Contact, and email sent from your domain - Two-factor sign-in for administrators, backups and rate limits	\$500
07	W-9s, through a specialist service 4 hrs × \$125 - Members submit from My Echelon; Ambassadors use a secure link from the same service - A service chosen in discovery for encryption, admin-only access, an audit log and deletion on your schedule. Connecting it is in the fee; its per-form charge is not	\$500
08	Content population 2 hrs × \$125 The first Company Partner profile, loaded with your team as the pattern	\$250
09	Testing, acceptance & launch 4 hrs × \$125 - Testing on iPhone, Android and desktop, then user acceptance testing with your team - Launch, admin training with a short written guide, and two weeks of monitoring	\$500
10	Project management 2 hrs × \$125 A staging link that updates every week, and one point of contact	\$250
60 hrs • total, fixed fee		\$7,500

After launch

Keeping it running

Nothing is on a retainer. Hosting and email are paid by IntenseGBD directly to the providers, on accounts in its name, for about **\$45** a month. We checked each price on September 25.

WHAT	NOTE	MONTHLY
Hosting Vercel Pro	Includes one developer seat	\$20
Plugins, forms and security add-ons Built in	Nothing to license	\$0
Database, sign-in and daily backups Supabase Pro	Backups kept for 7 days	\$25
Connect and sign-in email Resend	Free to 3,000 a month (100 a day), then \$20	\$0
Member email Constant Contact	Your plan; connecting it adds nothing	Varies
W-9 service Chosen in discovery	Its own fee per form	Varies
About		\$45

Maintenance hours **\$1,500**
Optional. Ten hours at \$150 an hour for updates, changes and new pages. Hours never expire. per 10-hour block

Bigger builds, each its own project

Each one is priced at the same project rate, and builds on the same database and sign-in as V0.

W-9s stored in the platform **\$3,750**

Encrypted, segregated storage inside the platform, with administrator-only access, two-factor sign-in, an audit log and a retention schedule. 30 hrs × \$125

Native iOS and Android app **\$12,500 to \$20,000**

Preliminary, on the same database and sign-in as V0. We would quote it properly after a few months of real use. 100 to 160 hrs, preliminary

Ambassador dashboard, Partner logins, Shared Value **Quoted**

Each one scoped in hours when you are ready for it. V0 already keeps the records they build on. in hours, when ready

About Upperhand

A creative studio run by founders. We've spent decades starting, running, and selling companies, and building the brands and products inside them. Now we do that work for ambitious brands we believe in, from the first strategy conversation through design and build, with the two of us in the room the whole way.

WHY WE STARTED THIS

The best hires either of us ever made were people who'd already run something. Most owners can't afford one of those. So we made ourselves hireable by the problem instead of by the year.

What happens next

01

Walk through it

Reply to John with a time next week. Thirty minutes with both of us, and your questions.

02

Sign

A master services agreement (MSA) and a scope of work for this project, based on this proposal, both signed electronically.

03

Kick off

Within five business days of signing and the first payment.

04

Launch

Six weeks from kickoff, on the timeline above, at theechelonsignature.com.

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Prepared for Joe Brocato, IntenseGBD, LLC · The Echelon, September 2026. Confidential. The Echelon name and logo belong to IntenseGBD, LLC.

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